Powers. “Do you realize that we had an air strike all arranged for Tuesday? Thank God it’s all over.”[1]

One can make an educated guess about what Kennedy was praying for during the service at St. Stephen’s. The previous afternoon he had called John Scali, whom he knew quite well, and thanked him for the service he had performed for Rusk and the administration by maintaining informal negotiations with Aleksandr Feklisov, the KGB man in Washington. “Do you go to church, John?” asked Kennedy. “Yes, I do, Mr. President,” came the answer. “Well, this afternoon or this evening,” continued Kennedy, “most of us should go to church and pray that we have not misunderstood and that we have correctly read what the Soviets are preparing to do, because there could be a very long tomorrow.”[2]

But not everyone was in church that morning. Robert McNamara spent his Sunday morning at the Pentagon, trying to calm down General Curtis LeMay and his colleagues in the Joint Chiefs Committee, who had their own reading of Khrushchev’s recently received letter to the president. Their meeting in the “tank,” the Pentagon conference room, began at 9:00 a.m. with LeMay demanding an assault on Cuba the next day. “I want to see the president later today, and I hope all of you will come with me,” he told the chiefs. “Monday will be the last day to attack the missiles before they become fully operational,” continued LeMay. When the ticker tape of Khrushchev’s speech was presented to the chiefs about 9:30 a.m., LeMay was anything but happy. “The Soviets may make a charade of withdrawal and keep some weapons in Cuba,” he told the gathering. McNamara and Paul Nitze, who joined the meeting, tried their best to calm down LeMay and the others, stating that the deal would leave the Americans in a much stronger position in the Caribbean than the Soviets. The generals, perplexed by Khrushchev’s sudden acquiescence to Kennedy’s offer, had to retreat.[3]

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KENNEDY RETURNED FROM MASS A WINNER. WHEN, SOON after 11:00 a.m., he entered the White House Cabinet Room, he felt the atmosphere of jubilation. His aides had just finished reading the translation of